Ref. No. 1713/Admin/Livelihood/2026-27

October 22, 2026

Name: Aadvwaya Passi
Programme: Apricot Oil Value-Addition and Livelihood Project
Organisation: Aarohi, Satoli, Nainital, Uttarakhand, India 263138
Period: 23rd-30th March 2026

Aarohi is a non-profit rural development organisation founded in 1992 and based in village Satoli, in the Kumaon Himalayas of Uttarakhand, India. For over three decades, Aarohi has been working with remote mountain communities, reaching nearly two hundred thousand people across 500 villages through healthcare, education, sustainable livelihoods and NRM. Through our cooperative brand Theth Pahadi, we help hill farmers and women's groups process and market local produce, including apricot kernels and Himalayan herbs.

Aadvwaya joined Aarohi in March 2026 and stayed in the Aarohi headquarters to explore how science could help strengthen livelihoods in our villages. During his time with us, he visited local communities, met farmers and SHG's (Self Help Groups), and learnt how apricot kernels are collected, pressed and sold in the local cottage industries.

Throughout his time with us, Aadvwaya approached every task with a positive attitude, intellectual curiosity and a genuine eagerness to learn. His passion for chemistry soon became apparent. He studied the composition of apricot kernel oil, rich in oleic and linoleic acids, and understood why it is a light, nourishing oil well suited to skin and hair care. He also explored why these same fats can turn rancid, and how careful pressing, filtering and storage protect quality. Building on this understanding, he proposed on developing a brand and sourcing apricot oil to make new range of apricot-oil products such as a lip balm, body butter, massage oil and handmade soap.

His idea of sourcing apricot oil from our cottage industries would increase the number of people employed, which is a major issue in the area: because of a lack of jobs, people migrate to urban towns. We believe that increased employment will reduce migration, which would greatly benefit the village. He is currently working on this brand, and his strong work ethic and scientific curiosity became apparent over the course of his stay. During the project, he interacted confidently with self-help group women, villagers and Aarohi employees, which showed his drive to take initiative for the rural community and his strong leadership qualities.

Without hesitation, I highly recommend Aadvwaya for any programme or institution of higher learning. His dedication, collaborative nature and commitment to using science for the good of others will make him a valuable addition to any academic community. I am confident he will be an asset to any institution or organisation he joins, to our country, and wherever life takes him. It was a pleasure having Aadvwaya with us at Aarohi.

Sincerely,

Pankaj Tewari
Executive Director, Aarohi
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